

THE YEAR OF UNTIED KNOTS

BOOK 5 OF 12

The Mantle

FATHER LUCAS · AUGSBURG

DEDICATION

For your children and grandchildren, near and far, and for every prayer you have said over them when they didn't know.



Father Lucas



BOOK 5

This book: Children and grandchildren: covering them, letting them go, blessing them, even when they are far away.

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

1. **The verse.** Read it slowly, out loud if you can.
2. **The word.** A short reading, about one minute.
3. **The prayer.** Say it as written, or in your own words.
4. **Today.** One small thing to do, a question to answer on the lines, and a box to tick when it's done.

If you miss a morning, don't catch up.
Turn to today's page and begin again.
Keep a pen beside this book and write in it.
These pages are yours.

BOOK 5

The Year of Untied Knots · Book 05 of 12 · Father Lucas

Days: 123 to 152 of 365 (30 mornings)

The knot: Children and grandchildren

Month candle: The Mantle

A LETTER FROM FATHER LUCAS

My friend,

You have been carrying names since the day each of them was born. The first one you held. The last one you couldn't. This month I want you to count them out loud, put them under Mary's mantle, and loosen your grip a little. Not because you love them less. Because you have held on with tired hands for a long time.

We'll talk about the child who worries you, the grandchild three time zones away, the son who stopped calling, the daughter who doubts. We'll bless, and write a card, and forgive ourselves for what we can't take back.

I can't promise how it ends. I can promise you won't pray alone.

Father Lucas

THE MONTH AT A GLANCE

Week 1: Count them, cover them, and say the worry plainly. Then teach and bless without a single speech.

Week 2: Reach across the miles, and put the old regrets and the unpaid loan into God's hands.

Week 3: Let them live their own lives, and pray for the people they love and the roads they travel.

Week 4: Thank them, say your mother's prayer, bless the table, remember the one who went before, and light the candle.

THREE PROMISES FOR THE MONTH

I. *I will say their names before I read the news.*

II. *I will bless them, even from far away.*

III. *I will let go of one thing at a time.*

IV. --

Psalm of the Month: 144

MY NAME



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WEEK 1

Count them, cover them, and say the worry plainly

DAYS 123 TO 129

Then teach and bless without a single speech.



DAY 123

Count Your Children

Then our sons will be like well-nurtured plants, our daughters like pillars carved to adorn a palace.

PSALM 144:12 (WEB)

Sit where you can see the refrigerator door, the one with the school photos still taped up. Some are thirty years old. Leave them there.

This month is about the people you carry. Today we do the simplest thing a parent can do. We count. Not the worries. The people. Say their names, oldest to youngest. The ones who call and the ones who don't. The grandchild whose last name changed. The one that's hard to say out loud.

Notice where your voice slows down. That's where the knot is.

Mary never loses count. Her mantle is wide, and it has room for every name you can't stop thinking about.

Mother Mary, here they are, in the order I love them, which is no order at all. Some are close and some are far, and some haven't called in a long time. You know each name better than I do. Count them with me this morning. Keep every one in your sight, and let me rest in knowing that not one of them is lost to you. Amen.



TODAY

Stand at the refrigerator and say your children's and grandchildren's names out loud, oldest to youngest. Take one breath after each name, and notice where your voice slows.

☐ DONE

Whose name did I say fastest, and whose slowest?

PSALM

144 — sons like well-tended plants, daughters like pillars; the psalm that counts the children as treasure.



DAY 124

The Blue Mantle

How precious is your loving kindness, God! The children of men take refuge under the shadow of your wings.

PSALM 36:7 (WEB)

A mantle isn't decoration, my friend. Think of the last time you laid a coat over a sleeping child in the back seat. You didn't ask if the child deserved it. You just covered them, and drove a little slower.

That's what Mary does with a name. She doesn't check first whether he's calling, or whether she still goes to church. She lifts the edge of the blue mantle, and the name goes under.

Try it with your own hands. It takes a minute. It isn't a trick. It's asking, plainly, the way you'd ask a neighbor to keep an eye on your house.

Our Lady, I'm taking each one by the hand this morning and bringing them to you. Cover the one who's tired. Cover the one who's proud. Cover the one who doesn't know she needs it. I can't be in all their houses today, but you can. Wrap them the way you wrapped your own Son, and keep them warm where I can't reach. Amen.



TODAY

Hold a family photograph. Say each name once, followed by the words "under your mantle." Make the Sign of the Cross over the photo when you're done.

☐ DONE

Which name did I want to say twice?

PSALM

17 — hide me under the shadow of your wings; the mantle's oldest picture.



DAY 125

The Child You Still Worry For

As one whom his mother comforts, so I will comfort you. You will be comforted in Jerusalem.

ISAIAH 66:13 (WEB)

There's a child on your list who is fifty-two and still gets the worry you gave him at four. A mother in my parish still listens for his car in the driveway, and he has gray in his beard.

The worry doesn't retire. It just changes coats. So today, give it one sentence. Not a solution. Then ask yourself: is this fear about what could happen to him, or about not being able to help? Plain words are easier to hand over than a fog.

Then give the sentence to Mary. She waited up for a son, too.

Holy Mother, you know the child I'm thinking of. You know what I'm afraid of, and I'm tired of carrying it into every quiet hour. I'm not asking how this ends. I'm asking you to walk beside this child where I can't, and to stay beside me while I wait. Take the sentence I've written. Keep it. Amen.



TODAY

Write one sentence that starts, "What I'm most afraid of for you is..." Don't send it. Fold it small and tuck it under your rosary or your Bible.

☐ DONE

What do I think my worrying is protecting them from?

PSALM

67 — may his face shine on us; the blessing a parent says over a child who isn't here.



DAY 126

Teach Them Without Words

We will not hide them from their children, telling to the generation to come the praises of the LORD, his strength, and his wondrous deeds that he has done.

PSALM 78:4 (WEB)

Walt ushered at our parish for decades. His granddaughter once told me she learned the Sign of the Cross watching him hold the collection basket in one hand and bless himself with the other. He never said a word to her about it.

That's how faith travels, my friend. Less like a lecture, more like a laugh, or the way you hold a fork. A child catches it without knowing.

So today you teach with your mouth closed. Do one small holy thing slowly, where a child might see it. Or where a memory might one day keep it.

Lord Jesus, I won't be able to explain everything to the ones I love. Let them see you in how I live, not only in how I talk. Let my small habits at the table, at the door, and in the car speak for me when I'm quiet. Make me honest. Make me steady. And whatever they remember of me, let it be gentle. Amen.



TODAY

Bow your head for ten seconds before your first bite today, even if you're eating alone. Do it slowly, the way you'd want a child to remember.

☐ DONE

What small habit of mine have they already caught?

PSALM

78 — we will not hide them from their children; the psalm of handing faith down.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

What you skip one day, you tend to skip two. It happens to everybody. Don't apologize and don't start over. Just open today's page, the way you'd pick up a dropped stitch.



DAY 127

A Blessing on the Forehead

May the LORD increase you more and more, you and your children. Blessed are you by the LORD, who made heaven and earth.

PSALM 115:14-15 (WEB)

My grandmother pressed her thumb on my forehead before I left the house. Cool, a little rough from the dishwater, smelling of soap. I was embarrassed in front of my friends. I would give a great deal to feel it again.

A blessing isn't magic. It's love with a shape. You can give it to a child who's asleep, to a grown man across the country, to a baby in a photograph. Distance doesn't change what a thumb means.

Today you'll make the shape. Slowly. The way she did, with the whole thumb.

Lord, bless this child, the one whose face I'm holding in my mind. Bless the forehead, and the thoughts behind it. Bless the hands, and where they go today. Bless the door they walk out of and the door they walk into. I can't follow them there, but I can raise my thumb and ask you to go ahead of them. Amen.



TODAY

Hold a photograph of one child or grandchild. With your thumb, trace a small cross on their forehead and whisper, "God bless you and keep you."

☐ DONE

Who blessed me like this, and did I ever thank them?

PSALM

89 — I will make known your faithfulness to all generations; a blessing is faithfulness passed forward.

128

DAY 128

Grandchildren in Another State

From the rising of the sun to its going down, the LORD's name is to be praised. The LORD is high above all nations, his glory above the heavens.

PSALM 113:3-4 (WEB)

There are three time zones between your kitchen and theirs. You know exactly what time it is where they are. You've checked it a hundred times. Lunch. School pickup. Bedtime stories you can't read.

It hurts. I won't make it smaller than it is. But the sun that rises over your garden is the one that goes down over their yard. Same sun. Same God under it. Distance is a measure of miles, not of love.

Today, send a little of your morning across those miles. No news, no question. A question needs an answer. A picture is a gift they can open whenever they have a minute.

Lord, the sun that is rising for me is setting for them. Be at their table tonight. Be in the car on the way to practice, and in the lamp beside the bed. Let them feel, without knowing why, that someone far away is thinking of them and glad they were born. Keep me close to them, even from here. Amen.



TODAY

Text a child or grandchild a photo of something from your morning, such as the coffee cup, the dog, or a bird on the fence. Add no question.

☐ DONE

What small piece of my day would they like to see?

PSALM

113 — from sunrise to sunset his name is praised; the psalm that stretches across a map.



DAY 129

Pray for Their Friends



One who walks with wise men grows wise, but a companion of fools suffers harm.

PROVERBS 13:20 (WEB)

Children don't raise themselves. Friends help. The boy who taught your son to drive stick. The girl who drove your daughter home the night the marriage ended. The co-worker who covers for her on the bad days.

You may not know their last names. You may have only a first one, and a voice on a speaker phone. That's enough. God doesn't need a last name.

Whoever stands beside your child in the hard hour is your business, too. Give them a place on your Names Page, and thank God they were there.

Lord Jesus, thank you for the friends who sit beside my child when I can't. Bless the one who listens. Bless the one who tells the truth. Keep them honest and kind, and keep them from steering my child wrong. Give them good days, a full table, and a friend of their own to lean on. I may never meet them. You know them by name. Amen.



TODAY

Add one name to your Names Page: a friend of your child's you have heard about, even if you only know the first name.

☐ DONE

Who has been quietly good to my child, without any credit?

PSALM

144 — happy are the people whose God is the LORD; a house is held up by the people around it.



WEEK 2

Week 2

DAYS 130 TO 136

Reach across the miles, and put the old regrets and the unpaid loan into God's hands.



DAY 130

The Prayer You Said at the Cradle

I prayed for this child, and the LORD has given me my petition which I asked of him.

1 SAMUEL 1:27 (WEB)

Think back to the first night. The small weight in the crook of your arm. Your own heart working too hard. You said something that night, even if you had no words. Maybe it was only, "Please."

That prayer is still on the books. God doesn't let it lapse because the baby grew a beard, or a mortgage, or a bad temper. A prayer for a child is never spent. It keeps working.

Say it again today. Don't polish it. The first one wasn't polished either. It was true, and that was enough.

Lord, the night you gave me this child, I begged you to keep them safe, and I meant it with my whole body. I mean it still. Here they are, older now, with troubles I can't guess. Keep my first prayer open. Hear it again in my older voice. Whatever I asked then, give them that, and more. Amen.



TODAY

Say aloud the first prayer you said over your child, or the plainest one you can find: "Please keep them safe." Say it three times, as if to a baby.

☐ DONE

What did I promise God the night they were born?

PSALM

17 — hear my righteous plea; the cry of a parent that God never files away.

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DAY 131

What You Wish You'd Done

I will restore to you the years that the swarming locust has eaten, the great locust, the grasshopper, and the caterpillar, my great army, which I sent among you.

JOEL 2:25 (WEB)

Every parent has a list. The long hours of work. The thing you said at the kitchen table in a tired voice. The year you didn't know how to talk to him, so you didn't.

I have my own list, and it's longer than you'd think. I let a whole year go by without visiting my mother. I know the taste of it.

You can't go back. But you can let God use it. Regret is only love that arrived late. Write it plainly, and let Mary read it first.

Mary, you were a mother, and you know how it feels to look back. Here are the things I wish I had done differently. I'm not making excuses, and I'm not beating myself up this morning. I'm putting them in your hands. Forgive what I did wrong. Use what I did right. And where it's still possible, give me one small chance to make it right. Amen.



TODAY

Write a two-line note to your child about one thing you wish you had done differently. Put it in an envelope. Decide tomorrow whether to send it.

☐ DONE

What could I say today that would not need to be perfect?

PSALM

73 — my flesh and my heart fail, but God is the strength of my heart; the psalm for a parent's regret.



DAY 132

Let Them Make Their Own Mistakes

and when you turn to the right hand, and when you turn to the left, your ears will hear a voice behind you, saying, "This is the way. Walk in it."

ISAIAH 30:21 (WEB)

You can see the pothole a mile off, and they're driving straight at it. Every muscle you own says grab the wheel.

But they aren't seven. The wheel is theirs. Your job now is harder: love them from the passenger seat, quiet and buckled in, pressing a brake that isn't there.

Say it once, kindly. Then let God have the wheel. He's a better driver than either of us, and he speaks to them in a voice you can't hear. Here's the odd part. Your silence leaves room for it.

Lord, I see what I see, and I'm afraid. Help me say it once, gently, and then close my mouth. Let me trust them to learn, and trust you to catch what I can't. When they fall, let me be the one who picks up the phone, not the one who says "I told you so." Quiet my hands on the wheel. Amen.



TODAY

Pick one decision of your child's that you can't control. Don't mention it, or stew over it, until nine tomorrow morning. When the worry comes, whisper "their wheel."

☐ DONE

When did someone let me fail, and what did it teach me?

PSALM

67 — God will bless us; the psalm for the parent who lets go and blesses instead.



DAY 133

The Loan That Never Came Back

But love your enemies, and do good, and lend, expecting nothing back; and your reward will be great, and you will be children of the Most High; for he is kind toward the unthankful and evil.

LUKE 6:35 (WEB)

Maybe it was a down payment, or a car, or a few months of rent. Maybe it was lent over the phone, with a promise to pay it back soon. You haven't mentioned it since. You haven't forgotten it, either. It sits at the table when they visit.

Here is a plain truth: you can be owed something and still be free of it. Not because it wasn't real. Because today you decide the child matters more than the amount.

You don't have to say "it's forgiven" to anyone. Hand it to Mary. She never asks whether it was fair.

Lord Jesus, you know what was owed and what was lost. You know how it felt to hear "I'll pay you back" and then hear nothing. I'm tired of keeping books on my own child. I give you this debt. Let it stop sitting between us at the table. Heal what hurts more than the money. Amen.



TODAY

Find a small object that stands for the loan, such as an old receipt or a coin. Put it in a box, close the lid, and say, "It's yours, Lord."

☐ DONE

What would I rather have back: the money, or the closeness?

PSALM

65 — you atoned for our transgressions; the psalm for debts nobody can pay back.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

The same tide that tied this knot is still out there. Resentment drifts back quietly, usually the next time they ask for something. When it does, open the box, look inside, and close it again.



DAY 134

A Recipe Passed Down

Tell your children about it, and have your children tell their children, and their children, another generation.

JOEL 1:3 (WEB)

There's a stained card in your kitchen. Or the recipe lives in your head and was never written down at all. Your mother's meatballs. Your grandmother's bread. The pinch that was never measured, and the smell of the sauce by four o'clock.

That recipe is a prayer in disguise. It says: you will be fed, and somebody thought of you first. Your children are hungry for more than the food. They're hungry for proof that they come from somewhere.

Don't wait for the right moment. Write it down while your handwriting is still yours.

Lord, thank you for every hand that fed me, and for the hands that fed them. Bless the kitchens I came from, and the long afternoons in them. Let the food I make carry something more than salt. Let my children, near or far, taste home when they taste it. And when I'm gone, let someone stir this pot and say my name. Amen.



TODAY

Clear one square foot of counter. Set the recipe card there, or a blank card and a pen, and write down the first three lines of the recipe.

☐ DONE

Who is the one person I most want to cook this for?

PSALM

78 — tell it to the generation to come; the family recipe is that psalm in flour and salt.



DAY 135

The Grown Child's Burden

Blessed be the Lord, who daily bears our burdens, even the God who is our salvation. Selah.

PSALM 68:19 (WEB)

They're forty. They're fifty. They carry a mortgage, a boss, a teenager, a bad knee. They don't tell you most of it, because they've decided you have enough.

And you want to carry it for them. You'd carry the whole house on your back if they'd let you. It breaks something in a parent to be refused.

But you can carry the weight in prayer, where they never have to watch you do it. And you can ask one honest question. Then listen longer than feels comfortable. Listening is the heaviest thing you can lift for them.

Gentle Mother, my child is carrying more than he says. I can hear it in how fast he says "fine." I can't take it from him, and he wouldn't let me. So I'm asking you. Lift the weight a little this morning. Send someone to help with the load. And when he calls, make me quiet enough to hear what he isn't saying. Amen.



TODAY

Call one grown child and ask only, "How are you, really?" Then listen without fixing anything. If they don't pick up, leave a short, warm message.

☐ DONE

When did I last listen to them without giving advice?

PSALM

89 — your faithfulness is around you; a God who carries what a parent cannot.



DAY 136

Their Marriage Is Not Yours

Therefore a man will leave his father and his mother, and will join with his wife, and they will be one flesh.

GENESIS 2:24 (WEB)

You love your daughter-in-law, or you're trying to. You're certain your son is making a mistake, or she is. You see what you see at their table: the silence, the sharp tone, the plate pushed away.

Here's the hard part. That marriage is not yours. Two people left their houses to start a third one, and you were invited as a guest.

A guest can pray. A guest can bring soup. A guest can keep quiet about the curtains. The best thing you can give that house is a peaceful parent at the door.

Lord, bless the marriage I can't fix. Bless my child and the one they chose. Bless the unwashed dishes and the long drives and the days when neither knows what to say. Keep my opinions behind my teeth. Let me be a quiet room they can walk into when they're tired of arguing. Teach me to love both without taking sides. Amen.



TODAY

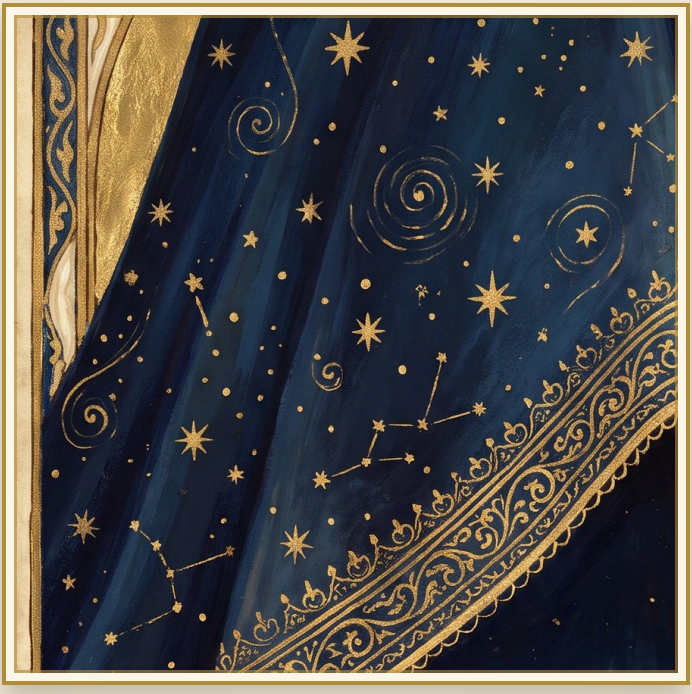
Say your child's spouse's name out loud, then one kind thing about them, even if you have to hunt for it. Say it to the kitchen wall. It still counts.

☐ DONE

What am I holding onto about their marriage that isn't mine?

PSALM

101 — I will walk within my house with a blameless heart; each house keeps its own door.



WEEK 3

Week 3

DAYS 137 TO 143

Let them live their own lives, and pray for the people they love and the roads they travel.



DAY 137

Pray for the Ones They Love

I thank my God whenever I remember you, always in every request of mine on behalf of you all, making my requests with joy,

PHILIPPIANS 1:3-4 (WEB)

There are people in your child's life you may never be fond of. The wife who looks at her phone at dinner. The husband whose jokes fall flat. The ex who is still the mother of your grandchild.

You don't have to be fond of them. You're only asked to pray for them. It's strange arithmetic, but it works. When the people your child loves are doing well, your child's days get lighter.

So pray for the in-laws, the boyfriend, the ex, the best friend. Whoever sits at your child's side, ask Mary to cover them, too.

Lord, I lift up the people my child loves. The ones I understand, and the ones I don't. Bless them with health and patience. Soften what is sharp in them, and in me. Where there's hurt between us, begin the repair. Let my family table, wherever it is, be wide enough for everyone my child calls their own. Amen.



TODAY

Read three names from your Names Page aloud, one of them an in-law or a friend of the family. Say one sentence of blessing for each.

☐ DONE

Who in my child's life do I find hardest to bless?

PSALM

113 — he lifts up the needy and sets them in a home; blessing reaches past our own blood.



DAY 138

Saint Joseph's Quiet Care

Joseph arose from his sleep, and did as the angel of the Lord commanded him, and took his wife to himself;

MATTHEW 1:24 (WEB)

Joseph never says a word in the Gospels. Not one. He gets up in the night, and he goes. He packs the donkey, finds the road, and works with his hands until the child is grown.

Some of us love like that. We don't say it well. We fix the gutter. We warm up the car. We fill the freezer before the drive home.

That love counts. Saint Joseph would call it a day's work. So for five minutes, be like him. No words. Just sit, and let your quiet care for them be the prayer.

Saint Joseph, you carried a child through the dark, and you never asked for thanks. Teach me to love like that, in the small jobs and the long quiet. Watch over the children I carry. Guard their sleep, their roads, and their work. And when I can't find the words, stand beside me and let my silence be enough. Amen.



TODAY

Sit in your favorite chair until the clock has moved five minutes. Say nothing. Let each person you love pass through your mind, one by one.

☐ DONE

What have I been doing for them that I never mentioned?

PSALM

144 — blessed be the LORD, my rock; the psalm for hands that work without applause.



DAY 139

The Teenager's Silence

But Mary kept all these sayings, pondering them in her heart.

LUKE 2:19 (WEB)

She answers in one word. He shuts the bedroom door. You asked how school was and got a sigh that could stop a clock. And if your teenager is now thirty-five, the sigh still sounds the same.

Silence isn't always rejection, my friend. Sometimes it's a person making up their mind who they are. Mary knew this. When her Son said hard things she didn't understand, the Gospel says she kept them and thought about them in her heart.

You can do that, too. Wait. Keep the door unlocked, the light low, and the kettle on. Breathe.

Mary, you waited for words that didn't come. You kept them close, and you trusted they'd make sense in time. Give me that kind of patience. Soften the door between me and this child. Teach me to be a calm presence, not a curious detective. Let them know, without my saying it, that when they're ready, I'm here. Amen.



TODAY

Breathe out the word "Mary" ten times, slowly, thinking of the child who has gone quiet. Then don't text them for an hour. Let the quiet be the gift.

☐ DONE

What might their silence be trying to say that words can't?

PSALM

17 — hear my speech, turn your ear to me; God hears what a teenager won't say.



DAY 140

A Rosary for Their Road

The LORD will keep your going out and your coming in, from this time forward, and forever more.

PSALM 121:8 (WEB)

Your grandson drives two hours to work. Your daughter flies out every other week. Someone you love is on a road right now, in rain or in dark, with a coffee going cold in the cup holder.

You can't ride along. But you can send a rosary in the passenger seat. Each bead is a mile you pray them through.

Take the beads in your hands. If you don't have a rosary, use your fingers. Mary knows what to do with ten small prayers. She has been traveling beside travelers a long time.

Mother Mary, ride with them today. Be in the passenger seat of the old truck and the middle seat of the airplane. Keep their eyes open and their tempers short. Keep the other drivers kind. And bring them home to a warm kitchen. Whatever the road asks of them, let them find you on it. Amen.



TODAY

Take your rosary in your hands, or use your fingers. Pray one decade, ten Hail Marys, for the road of one person you love.

☐ DONE

Where, exactly, is the road they're on this morning?

PSALM

67 — God will bless us; the psalm for a blessing that travels on every road.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

Someone on your Names Page is on a road today and doesn't know you're praying. That's the whole point of it. Say their name once more tonight, and come back for the next page.



DAY 141

Send a Card

Anxiety in a man's heart weighs it down, but a kind word makes it glad.

PROVERBS 12:25 (WEB)

A card in the mailbox is a small miracle now. Among the bills and the flyers sits an envelope in a hand they know. Your handwriting, a little shaky. A grandchild opens it before anything else.

You don't have to write much. Three lines. Something you noticed about them, something you remember, something you hope. They will keep it in a drawer for years. I've cleaned out a few drawers, and I can tell you what turns up at the bottom.

Say it on paper while you can, in ink, with your own odd capital letters.

Lord, bless the little card I'm about to write. Guide my pen, though it shakes. Let the words be simple and true. Let my grandchild feel, when they open it, that someone in the world is proud of them for no reason at all. Carry it safely to the right hands, on the right day. Amen.



TODAY

Write three lines in a card to a child or grandchild: something you noticed, something you remember, something you hope. Address the envelope and set it by the door.

☐ DONE

What do I remember about them that they've long since forgotten?

PSALM

78 — we will not hide them from their children; what you write down outlives the afternoon.



DAY 142

The Child Who Doubts God

Immediately the father of the child cried out with tears, "I believe. Help my unbelief!"

MARK 9:24 (WEB)

Your son stopped going to Mass at nineteen. Your granddaughter calls it fairy tales. Your daughter says she's "spiritual." You said nothing at the table, and you've been saying it in your head ever since.

Listen to the father in the Gospel. He didn't say, "I have strong faith." He said, "I believe. Help my unbelief." He prayed with both at once, doubt and love side by side.

A doubting child is not a lost child. A doubt is a question, and questions are how faith gets built. Pray the father's prayer for them.

Lord Jesus, I believe. Help my unbelief, and help theirs. I don't understand why they walked away, and I won't pretend to. Be patient where I am not. Send them one honest friend, one quiet moment, one question that gets under the door. Don't let my worrying be the loudest voice they hear. Let yours be, softly, in the quiet. Amen.



TODAY

Say out loud, "I believe. Help my unbelief," once for yourself and once for the child who doubts. Then stay quiet for one full minute.

☐ DONE

What would I want them to know if I couldn't argue?

PSALM

89 — I will make known your faithfulness to all generations; love that outlasts an argument.



DAY 143

Faith They Will Remember

having been reminded of the sincere faith that is in you, which lived first in your grandmother Lois and your mother Eunice and, I am persuaded, in you also.

2 TIMOTHY 1:5 (WEB)

Mrs. Doyle cleaned our church for twenty years. Her grandson told me he can still smell the lemon polish, and still see her cross herself at the door, "like it was nothing." It was everything.

Faith lives in objects first. A child sees a crucifix every day and never asks why. Years later, in a hospital hallway in another city, they'll remember it.

Look around your house through a child's eyes. What does it say about what matters? Move one thing so it says it plainly, and let a child find it without being told.

Lord, make my home a quiet witness. Let the picture on the wall, the beads on the hook, and the Bible on the shelf say what I can't. When my grandchildren walk through my door, let them feel the peace. And someday, when they stand in a hard place far from here, let them remember where you lived. Amen.



TODAY

Move one holy picture, crucifix, or rosary to a spot a child would see first when they walk in. Step back and look at it with their eyes.

☐ DONE

What would a child guess I care about most, from my walls?

PSALM

113 — from sunrise to sunset his name is praised; faith that is visible in a home.



WEEK 4

Week 4

DAYS 144 TO 152

Thank them, say your mother's prayer, bless the table, remember the one who went before, and light the candle.



DAY 144

Mary and the Missing Boy

After three days they found him in the temple, sitting in the middle of the teachers, both listening to them and asking them questions.

LUKE 2:46 (WEB)

For three days Mary and Joseph didn't know where he was. Imagine the walk home, counting faces in the caravan. Imagine her face when she found him at last, sitting among the teachers. She isn't calm. She is a mother.

Some of you know that look from the inside. A child missing in a different way: from home, from you, from the family. Mary doesn't tell you to stop looking. She knows what it is to look, and to keep walking, and to keep a name in your mouth.

Today, say that name where Mary can hear it.

Mary, you know the long road home with an empty place beside you. I'm walking it too. Here is the one I'm looking for. Look with me. Go where I can't go, and knock where I'm afraid to knock. If I'm to wait, give me the strength of waiting. If I'm to move, show me one step. Hold my hand as you hold theirs. Amen.



TODAY

Hold a photograph of the child who feels far away. Say their name, then say, "Mary, you know where they are." Make the Sign of the Cross over the photo.

☐ DONE

What would I say first if I found them tomorrow?

PSALM

144 — rescue me; the cry of a parent who is searching.



DAY 145

Under the Mantle at Night

when I remember you on my bed, and think about you in the night watches.

PSALM 63:6 (WEB)

It's late, and your mind has done the roll call again. Who's driving. Who's sick. Who didn't text back. The house creaks. The clock is slow with its minutes.

Here is the only thing I know to do at night, and I've done it for years. I picture the mantle, wide and soft and blue, and I tuck every name under the edge. Then I stop being in charge. Not forever. Just until morning.

You aren't neglecting them by resting. Our Lady keeps the night shift. She doesn't sleep, and she doesn't mind.

Our Lady, the house is quiet and my mind is not. I give you the names I've carried around all day. Take them for the night. I'm putting them under the mantle one at a time, and then I'm lying down. Watch the roads. Watch the sleeping. Watch me, if I wake. In the morning I'll pick up my share again. Amen.



TODAY

Tonight, light a candle and count ten breaths while you watch the flame, with the people you love in your mind. Then blow it out and say, "Amen."

☐ DONE

Which worry will I leave under the mantle tonight?

PSALM

102 — hear my prayer, let my cry come to you; for the hour when the roll call starts again.



DAY 146

The Neighbor's Child



See that you don't despise one of these little ones, for I tell you that in heaven their angels always see the face of my Father who is in heaven.

MATTHEW 18:10 (WEB)

There's a child on your street who needs a grown-up to notice. The one who rides a bike alone. The girl whose mother works nights. The boy next door who is quiet at the mailbox.

You can't fix their lives. You can be one steady adult in view. A wave. A name remembered. "How did the test go?" It costs nothing, and it can be the best part of a child's day.

Jesus says their angels see the Father's face. If heaven pays that much attention, we can pay a little. And somewhere, a stranger is doing the same for yours.

Lord, bless the children on my street whom I only know by sight. Keep them safe going to school and coming home. Give each one a grown-up who sees them. If I can be one, make me ready. And somewhere far from here, put a kind person in my grandchild's path, to greet them by name today. Amen.



TODAY

Say a kind word to the first child you see today: a neighbor's, a stranger's, anyone's. Use their name if you know it. Smile like you mean it.

☐ DONE

Which child near me might need someone to notice?

PSALM

17 — keep me as the apple of your eye; every child is somebody's apple of the eye.



DAY 147

What They Gave You

Behold, children are a heritage of the LORD. The fruit of the womb is his reward.

PSALM 127:3 (WEB)

We spend so much time on what we gave our children. The lessons. The sacrifices. The rides in the rain. It's good to remember. But turn the page today and read the other side: what they gave you.

Your daughter made you laugh when you thought you couldn't. Your son's clumsy hug at the airport. A grandchild who fixed your phone, kindly, with endless patience. They made you someone different from the person you were before.

The psalm calls children a heritage, and a heritage is something you receive, not something you earn. A child is a gift in both directions. Name the gift, and God hears it as thanks.

Lord, thank you for what my children gave me. They taught me patience, though I fought it. They gave me laughter in the hard years. They made me braver than I wanted to be. Bless them for it, and bless me for being allowed to watch. Let them know, someday, how much they gave. Amen.



TODAY

Write three words for what one child or grandchild has given you. Read them out loud, then say, "Thank you, Lord," three times.

☐ DONE

What changed in me because they were born?

PSALM

67 — the earth has yielded its increase; the psalm of a harvest you didn't see coming.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

I let thankfulness slip once. I took a good brother for granted until the phone went quiet. It came back, but slowly. Don't wait for a quiet house to count the gifts.

148

DAY 148

Your Own Mother's Prayer

My son, listen to your father's instruction, and don't forsake your mother's teaching;

PROVERBS 1:8 (WEB)

Somewhere behind every one of us is a woman on her knees. Your mother. Your grandmother. An aunt in a kitchen with a rosary in her apron pocket. Her hands smelled of dish soap and onions. Whether you knew it or not, she prayed you through nights you survived.

Father Jakob, long ago, in Augsburg, kept his mother's short prayer folded inside his book and said it before his own. He liked that the line didn't break: her words, his lips, a child's ears.

Today, say hers. Even half remembered, the prayers she said still count, and they still reach the people she loved.

God of my mother, hear the prayer she taught me. I say it now in her voice, the way she would have said it, a little too fast. Thank you for every night she knelt for me. Let her prayers keep covering my children. Carry my words to hers across every distance. Let the line never break. Amen.



TODAY

Say the prayer your mother or grandmother taught you, even if you can only half remember it. Say it out loud, in her voice if you can.

☐ DONE

Which of her words do I still hear when I'm afraid?

PSALM

78 — what our fathers told us we will not hide from their children; mothers count too.

149

DAY 149

A Voice Message

I will sing of the loving kindness of the LORD forever. With my mouth, I will make known your faithfulness to all generations.

PSALM 89:1 (WEB)

Last winter Tom, my neighbor, played me a voicemail from his daughter. Eleven seconds. "Hi, Dad, just checking on the roast." He has kept it a long time. He played it twice while I drank his coffee.

A text gets read. A voice gets heard. Yours is the voice a baby once knew in the dark, and a grandchild at a desk will take thirty seconds to hear it.

Say nothing big. "It's me. I made the soup you like." Don't wait for a time that fits. A voice is a small mantle laid across a distance.

Lord, give me a few easy words today. Let my voice be warm and not too long. Let it reach the one who needs a familiar sound, at the moment they need it. Take away the nervous feeling that I'm bothering them. Bless the message before I send it, and bless the ears that will hear it. Amen.



TODAY

Leave a voicemail or voice message for one child or grandchild that says only, "I was thinking of you. I love you. No need to call back."

☐ DONE

What is the one sentence I want them to hear in my voice?

PSALM

89 — with my mouth I will make known your faithfulness; a voice carries what a text can't.



DAY 150

Bless the Table

Your wife will be as a fruitful vine in the innermost parts of your house, your children like olive shoots around your table.

PSALM 128:3 (WEB)

Think of the last time everyone sat at your table. Maybe it was years ago. Voices overlapping, someone asking for the salt, a child sliding off a chair. Now it may be you, one plate, and the radio.

A table is a kind of altar. Bread and love are served on it. You can bless it whether it's full or not. Don't let a quiet kitchen talk you out of it.

Put both hands flat on it. Feel the wood. This table has held the whole story. It can hold today, too.

Lord, bless this table where my family has laughed and argued and prayed. Bless every seat, the ones that are full and the ones that are not. Bless the hands that cooked here, and the ones that carved their initials underneath. Let this be a place where people feel at home, now and as long as it stands. Feed us, Lord, in every way we hunger. Amen.



TODAY

Rest both hands flat on your table for one full minute. Whisper the name of each person who has ever eaten there.

☐ DONE

Whose laughter do I most want to hear at this table?

PSALM

113 — he settles the lonely in a home; thanks said over a table.



DAY 151

The Child Who Went Before

He will wipe away every tear from their eyes. Death will be no more; neither will there be mourning, nor crying, nor pain any more. The first things have passed away.

REVELATION 21:4 (WEB)

Some of you are carrying a child who isn't here anymore. The years haven't changed the name you whisper when the house is quiet.

I won't make it smaller than it is. A parent isn't meant to outlive a child, and nothing I write will fix that. I only want you to know that child is not lost to God, and you're not carrying this alone, either.

Today, sit with that name. You don't have to pray. Let Mary sit with you. And if this isn't your sorrow, pray for someone who carries it.

Mary, you know what it is to love a child past the edge of sight. Here is mine. I say the name again today. Hold this child where I can't. Hold me, too, while I miss them. Let my love be a door and not a wall. And in your time, gather us both. Amen.



TODAY

Sit with your coffee for two full minutes. Say your child's name once, softly, then stay quiet. If tears come, let them.

☐ DONE

What do I want to tell them that I haven't said yet?

PSALM

120 — in my distress I cried to the LORD, and he answered me; the psalm of a grief with no one to tell.



DAY 152

The Mantle Candle

He will cover you with his feathers. Under his wings you will take refuge. His faithfulness is your shield and rampart.

PSALM 91:4 (WEB)

This is the last day of the month. Think back to the names you counted on the first morning. Some are the same. Some feel a little different. You may be the one who changed.

Tonight, light the Mantle Candle and say each name to Mary, one by one. It burns as long as you like. When it's done, light it again.

The knot of children is never finished. A loosened knot can tie again if we leave it. It can also be loosened again by the same hands, with the same love. That's all I've ever known to do.

Mary, here is the candle for the mantle. Under it I place every name I counted a month ago, and the ones I've added since. Cover them in the morning and in the night, near and far. Take my worry, and give me back the peace of a parent who has handed their children to someone stronger. I'll light this again tomorrow. Amen.



TODAY

Light a candle. Say each name on your Names Page aloud, and after each one say, "Under your mantle." Blow out the flame with an Amen.

☐ DONE

Which name will I carry into next month with a lighter hand?

PSALM

144 — happy are the people whose God is the LORD; the first psalm of the month, closing it.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

I closed a book like this once and thought, that's done. Within a week the old worry was back at my table. Not as failure. Just as weather. Open tomorrow's page, and keep the candle near.

LOOKING BACK AT BOOK 5

Take a pen. There is no right answer. Tick a box if it's true.

1. Which name did I say more gently at the end of the month than at the beginning? ☐

2. What one thing did I stop trying to control? ☐

3. Who did I call, text, or write to, and what happened? ☐

4. Whose name do I want to carry into next month? ☐

A LETTER TO CLOSE THE MONTH

My friend,

Thirty mornings ago you counted your children out loud. Look at that list again. Some of it hurts less. Some of it may hurt the same, and that's honest, too. Nothing here was promised to be fixed. It was promised to be held, and you held it.

A knot you loosen can tie again, if you leave it alone. I'm not saying that to scare you. I'm saying it because I've watched good people let the page slip for a week and feel the old tightness return. The cure is small. Open tomorrow's page. Three minutes. The mantle is wide, and it is still there.

Father Lucas



THE SEAL AND THE CANDLE

The Seal of Book 5: Under the Blue Mantle. Date:

The Mantle Candle: Light a candle. Say every name on your Names Page aloud, and after each one say, "Under your mantle." Blow out the flame with an "Amen."

What changed this month:

Names to add:

"Turn to Book 6 tomorrow."



THE YEAR OF UNTIED KNOTS

Book 5 of 12



NEXT · BOOK 6 · THE OPEN DOOR